# *Vietnam Workcamp 2026: Building skills, homes and friendships*



Nairana and Mirrabooka Study Centres have a long tradition of encouraging university students to serve communities in less fortunate circumstances through practical workcamps. In 2026, the workcamp took place in Dong Kho, a village approximately three hours from Ho Chi Minh City, Vietnam.

Twenty volunteers participated in the project. The team included young men from Mirrabooka and Nairana Study Centres in Sydney, Glenrowan Study Centre in Auckland, and the United States. Before travelling, each volunteer was asked to raise $1,000 towards the project. Together, they raised $20,000 to fund the installation of a water-filtration unit for the village and the construction of a new home for a family living in difficult conditions.

**Learning on the job**



Working alongside local Vietnamese tradesmen, the volunteers dug foundations, poured concrete, laid bricks and rendered walls. Most had little or no previous construction experience, so the first few days involved a steep learning curve—and plenty of quality control from their more experienced Vietnamese colleagues.

The language barrier added another challenge. The local workers often attracted the volunteers' attention by tapping their tools and then used gestures to demonstrate what needed to be done. Simple instructions could usually be understood, but more complicated tasks, such as moving scaffolding or learning how to lay bricks correctly, required patience and creativity on both sides.



At first, many of the volunteers struggled even to keep cement on a trowel. With time and repetition, however, they found their rhythm, improved their skills and became more adept at understanding their Vietnamese co-workers.

**Connecting with the village**



The construction site soon became a lively meeting place. Volunteers and local workers shared refreshments, laughed together and attempted—with varying degrees of success—to learn phrases in one another's languages.

The presence of foreign volunteers also attracted the curiosity of the village children. During breaks, the volunteers spoke with them and played games of soccer. Some children later joined in by helping with small but meaningful jobs around the site. On one occasion, a group of boys aged about six to eight left their nearby fishing spot to help stack and move a pile of bricks.



Over the two weeks, these daily interactions enabled the volunteers to get to know the villagers and better understand their lives. They learned that a 14-year-old girl had stopped attending school, despite wanting to continue her education, because her family had no means of transport.



As funds remained from the original $20,000 raised, the volunteers were able to surprise her on their final day by taking her to a bicycle shop. She chose her own bicycle and can now look forward to returning to school.

**A lasting contribution**

The completed water-filtration system will improve access to clean water in a village that has relied on bottled water. The new brick house, twice the size of the family's former tin home, will provide safer and more comfortable living conditions.



A Bas Relief of St Josemaria in Ho Chi Minh City

On their final morning in Dong Kho, the volunteers rose early and climbed the long flight of stairs to the Shrine of Our Lady of Ta Pao. There, together with local Catholics, they attended Mass and gave thanks for the experience. They then returned to Ho Chi Minh City for a few days of rest and sightseeing before travelling home.

The volunteers made a tangible and lasting contribution to Dong Kho, but the village also left a deep impression on them. They returned home tired, grateful and more aware of the difference that generosity, hard work and friendship can make.